

Beaux-Arts

France had been one of the first countries to create a formal system of architectural training with the founding of the Académie Royale d'Architecture in 1671. Although the academy was closed during the French Revolution, its function was revived in the École des Beaux-Arts, which Napoleon opened in 1803. Developed from the teachings at the new school, Beaux-Arts – 'fine arts' – architecture is an ornate classical style that spread rapidly, emerging in public buildings around the world.

Beaux-Arts architecture focused on symmetrical plans and drew inspiration from classical styles. It often features slightly oversized details, high rusticated basements, deep cornices, and recessed arches and pediments that are commonly adorned with reliefs. The Paris Opéra (1860–75, opposite), designed by Charles Garnier (1825–98), and the Petit Palais (1896–1900) by Charles Girault (1851–1932) – both students of the École des Beaux-Arts – embody the style.

